CHAPTER 8 · DEEP DIVE · A HOUSE DIVIDED

The Overland Campaign

Grant's brutal, relentless arithmetic — the campaign that bled the Confederacy to death in six weeks. 1864.

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

Grant's brutal, relentless arithmetic — the campaign that bled the Confederacy to death in six weeks. 1864.

When is a commander willing to accept terrible losses — and why might that be the only way to win?

A New Kind of General

SPRING 1864

In March 1864, Lincoln made Ulysses S. Grant general-in-chief of all Union armies. Grant understood something his predecessors had not: the way to win was not to capture a city, but to destroy Lee's army — and to never stop pressing it.

In May he launched the Overland Campaign, driving straight at Lee in Virginia through a series of savage battles: the Wilderness, Spotsylvania, and Cold Harbor.

General Grant's "Council of War" at Massaponax Church, Virginia — photograph, May 1864, public domain (Library of Congress).

Grant Plans the Next Move

MASSAPONAX CHURCH, VA., MAY 1864

Grant (leaning over the pew, examining a map) directs the campaign in the field. Unlike the generals before him, he would not retreat after a bloody battle — he kept moving south.

General Grant's "Council of War" at Massaponax Church, Virginia — photograph, May 1864, public domain (Library of Congress).

≈55,000

THE COST IN SIX WEEKS

The losses were staggering. In roughly six weeks, Grant's army suffered about 55,000 casualties — nearly as many men as Lee had in his entire army. At Cold Harbor, some 7,000 Union soldiers fell in a matter of minutes.

Northern newspapers called Grant a "butcher." But here is the grim logic: the Union could replace its losses. The Confederacy could not. Every soldier Lee lost was gone for good.

Turning points, 1863–65 — map, © ShadowDog Digital Studios (SDS Digital Collection).

He Would Not Turn Back

THE RELENTLESS DIFFERENCE

Earlier Union generals had fought Lee, taken heavy losses, and retreated to lick their wounds. Grant did the opposite. After each bloody battle, he moved his army deeper south, forcing Lee to keep fighting.

This was attrition — a war of wearing down. Grant was trading casualties he could afford for casualties Lee could not. By June 1864 he had pinned Lee's army at Petersburg, and the long siege that would end the war began.

General Grant's "Council of War" at Massaponax Church, Virginia — photograph, May 1864, public domain (Library of Congress).

ULYSSES S. GRANT, 1864

I … propose to fight it out on this line if it takes all summer.

— GEN. ULYSSES S. GRANT, DISPATCH FROM SPOTSYLVANIA

Do the Arithmetic

YOUR TURN

You'll work with the casualty data from 1864 and practice turning numbers into an argument — deciding whether Grant was a "butcher" or the general who finally knew how to win.